everyone. The matter led to a tense dispute between colonial authorities and the emerging YMBA. The organization passed resolutions stating that foreign companies could not use the Buddha and pagodas in their trade or brand marks. Furthermore, the group would forbid the wearing of footwear in religious places. The British perceived this to now be a political matter, which they claimed the YMBA had no right to engage in. Thein Maung's action transformed a religious matter into one that ultimately was anticolonial and nationalist.

The shoe question indirectly led to a rift and factionalization within the Burmese nationalist cause. The older members wanted to take a more moderate conciliatory path working within the system to push for change. The younger members wanted changes in orientation and strategy, which they believed would empower the nationalist cause.

A TURNING POINT IN THE NATIONALIST STRUGGLE: THE HSAYA SAN REBELLION OF 1930–1931

Multiple rebellions had broken out in early 20th-century Burma. In 1910, petty cultivators took up arms in Sagaing, Shwebo, and Chindwin districts. A few years later, the authorities faced upheaval in the Mayoka uprising. In the late 1920s, an insurrection emergence occurred in the Tharrawaddy area.

San, a former medical practitioner and teacher, was born into a rural family in independent Burma in 1879. His early career focused on urging Burmese peasants to rely on traditional medicines rather than the expensive Western remedies. He published several works outlining his ideas on his preference for traditional Burmese medical practices. During his travels, he observed the crushing poverty that the majority of Burmese peasants suffered. He eventually joined the GCBA, being put in charge of a research project dealing with British policies in rural areas. The focus was on the collection of taxes and the ill-treatment of Burmese peasants at the hands of British authorities. San promoted the idea of a “people's volunteers” to oppose colonial authorities, which was considered too radical for the mainstream of Burmese activists. San believed the only alternative was armed insurrection.